Paying for Youngstown State: Two Family Pathways

Crown Roots Foundation · Financial aid, scholarship stacking, and the YSU Foundation

For: Crown Roots families and Crown Roots mentors

About this guide: This guide explains how aid works at YSU. It does not estimate your cost. Every family's situation is different, so get your own numbers from YSU's official estimators (below). Only YSU can decide your final aid, and only after it receives and reviews your completed FAFSA.

Start Here: What Cost of Attendance Means

Every college publishes a Cost of Attendance (COA). It is YSU's *estimate* of what a year of college could cost. It is not your bill.

COA has two parts:

- Direct costs: tuition, fees, and (if you live on campus) housing and food. These show up on your YSU bill.
- Indirect costs: books, transportation, and personal expenses. You pay these yourself, and they don't show up on the bill.

Your real bill depends on your own situation: your courses and any course, college, or digital-material fees; your housing assignment; and the meal plan you choose. That's why two students at the same school can see very different bills.

The two numbers to look at in your own results:

- What's on the bill: direct costs minus grants and scholarships.
- Full net price: the full cost of attendance minus grants and scholarships. This is the real cost of the year, including books and travel. Don't just compare bills.

Get your own numbers

Tool	What it tells you
YSU Tuition Estimator	Tuition and fees for your course load, college, and residency
Housing and Residence Life: Rates	Housing and meal plan options and costs
YSU Financial Aid Estimator	An estimate of the aid you may be eligible for

Results from these tools are estimates. Your actual aid is decided only after YSU reviews your FAFSA.

How the Money Stacks at YSU

Layer	What it is	How to get it	Need-based?
1. Pell Grant	Federal grant, up to $7,395	FAFSA	Yes
2. FSEOG	Federal grant for the lowest incomes; funds are limited	FAFSA	Yes
3. PA State Grant	Pennsylvania grant; smaller at out-of-state schools like YSU	FAFSA by May 1, plus PHEAA State Grant Form	Yes

4. YSU PA Grant Match	YSU matches the PA State Grant	Automatic with the PA grant	Follows the PA grant
5. Scholarships for Excellence	Merit, $1,000 to $5,000 by GPA and SAT	Apply to YSU with transcripts by **February 15**	No
6. Housing Grant	For students living on campus; funds are limited	Separate application, first come, first served	No
7. YSU Foundation	1,100+ scholarships, $500 and up, $11M+ a year	One application by **February 1**	Some are, many aren't
8. Honors College and department awards	Extra awards for Honors and specific majors	Honors application; department contacts	Mostly no
9. Outside scholarships	Local, regional, state, national	Each one separately	Varies
10. Work-study or campus job	Earned, paid to the student	FAFSA and job search	Work-study is
11. Loans	Borrowed, repaid with interest	Accept only what's left	Last resort

Some federal and YSU funds, like FSEOG and the Housing Grant, are limited and not guaranteed. Apply early.

YSU's rules, written in Ohio law (Ohio Admin. Code 3356-8-10):

- Total aid can't go over the full cost of attendance.
- If extra money comes in, **YSU reduces loans first**, before scholarships.
- If aid is more than what's on the bill, **the student may get a refund** to help with books, travel, and personal costs.

Layers 1 to 4 depend on income. Layers 5 to 9 depend on effort. That's the whole conversation with any family.

YSU merit awards (Scholarships for Excellence)

Award	Per year	With SAT	Test-optional
First Opportunity	$1,000	3.0 GPA, 990 SAT	3.0 to 3.49 GPA
Red and White	$2,000	3.0 GPA, 1110 SAT	3.5 to 3.89 GPA
Deans'	$3,000	3.5 GPA, 1220 SAT	3.9 GPA and up
President's	$4,000	3.5 GPA, 1290 SAT	Not available
Trustees'	$5,000	Valedictorian	Not available

One award per student. Renews with a 3.0 GPA in college.

Pathway A: Family Income Under $75,000

What usually drives aid: For many families at this income, the need-based layers (1 to 4) carry more of the weight. How much depends on your full FAFSA, including family size and assets, not income alone.

Step 1: Run YSU's Financial Aid Estimator

Use your family's real numbers. This gives you a starting estimate for the need-based layers.

Step 2: Close the gap with effort

Add what effort can bring in: a stronger merit award (see the table above), the YSU Foundation application, and local and outside scholarships. Each one you win stacks on top.

Step 3: The refund possibility

If total aid goes past what's on the bill, the extra can come back to the student, up to the full cost of attendance, to help with books, travel, and personal costs. Students we've worked with have closed the gap entirely at YSU engineering by stacking Foundation and outside scholarships, and one ended up with money back. That came from applying early and widely, not from income alone. It's what's possible, not what to expect.

What to watch

- Apply for the Housing Grant early. It runs out.
- Report every outside scholarship. At YSU it reduces loans first.
- Refile the FAFSA every year. Pell, FSEOG, and the PA grant are renewed one year at a time.
- Compare honestly: at this income, Pennsylvania public options can come out ahead on grants alone. The PA State Grant is larger at in-state schools, and Pitt-Johnstown's tuition pledge covers tuition for lower-income families. YSU wins when the Foundation and outside scholarships come through, and on programs and fit.

Pathway B: Family Income Over $75,000

What usually drives aid: At this income, need-based grants may be small or zero, depending on family size and assets. Treat layers 1 to 4 as a bonus, not the plan. Merit, Foundation, and outside scholarships don't care about income. For this family they're most of the plan.

Step 1: Run YSU's Financial Aid Estimator

Even if you expect little need-based aid, run it. It shows where you start.

Step 2: Effort carries more of the weight

- **Merit:** every step up the Scholarships for Excellence table is money every year, for four years.
- **YSU Foundation:** one application by February 1 puts you in front of 1,100+ scholarships.
- **Local and outside scholarships:** apply widely.

Step 3: Cover what's left without heavy debt

Option	Notes
Campus job	Part-time hours during the school year
Summer job savings	Varies
529 or family savings	Varies
Federal Direct Loan (student)	Up to $5,500 the first year, only if needed
Avoid: Parent PLUS loans	This is the parent's debt, with higher fees

What to watch

- **Still file the FAFSA.** Many YSU Foundation scholarships, the PA grant and match, and federal loans need it. The 2027-28 form takes about 15 minutes.
- **The test score matters more here.** With a 3.5 GPA, a higher SAT can move a student up one or two merit tiers. Check the table above.
- **Honors College:** 3.5 GPA and 1240 SAT (or 26 ACT), separate application. Ask about Honors awards and housing.

- **Income dropped?** If the family's income is lower now than in the tax year the FAFSA uses (job loss, divorce, medical bills), ask YSU Financial Aid for a special circumstances review.
- **Do not file as independent to hide parent income.** Working and paying taxes doesn't make a student under 24 independent. A false answer can mean paying aid back.
- **Compare honestly:** over $75,000, Pitt's tuition pledge no longer applies, and Pennsylvania state schools offer less grant aid at this income. YSU's out-of-state price and large Foundation often make it one of the strongest options for this family.

Side by Side

	Under $75K	Over $75K
What usually drives aid	Need-based grants (layers 1 to 4), based on the full FAFSA	Merit, Foundation, and outside scholarships (layers 5 to 9)
Biggest lever	Foundation and local scholarships	Test score, Foundation, and local scholarships
Realistic goal	Close the gap, with a possible refund	Shrink the gap, then cover the rest with work and savings
First step	FAFSA and YSU's Financial Aid Estimator	FAFSA and YSU's Financial Aid Estimator

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The Four-Year View

- **Merit renews** with a 3.0 GPA. Keep grades up from day one.
- **Reapply to the YSU Foundation every year.** Continuing students can win awards tied to their major.

- Refile the FAFSA every year, by May 1 for the PA grant.
- Keep applying to outside scholarships in college. Fewer students do, so the odds get better.
- Ask YSU Financial Aid whether the Housing Grant renews after the first year.

Talking With Families: Crown Roots Mentor Notes

Start from the need-based estimate, then move in either direction:

1. Have the family run YSU's estimators with their real numbers. That's the starting point (layers 1 to 4).
2. Show what effort adds (layers 5 to 9): a better test score, the Foundation application, local scholarships.
3. Talk through what's left and how to cover it, from a possible refund to work and savings.

Let the family run the numbers themselves. Don't write a dollar figure down for them. YSU's Financial Aid office has seen that families remember the number and forget the disclaimer. The estimators explain that results are estimates, and the real answer comes from YSU after the FAFSA.

Say this: "Your income decides where you start. Your effort decides where you finish."

Don't say: "You'll go for free." Say: "Students like you have closed the gap by applying early and widely. Here's the plan."

Key Dates

Date	What
Fall of senior year	File the FAFSA (2027-28 opened Sept 24, 2026)

As early as possible	YSU Housing Grant application
February 1	YSU Foundation scholarship application
February 15	Apply to YSU with transcripts for Scholarships for Excellence
May 1	FAFSA deadline for the PA State Grant, plus the State Grant Form

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Questions about your aid? YSU Office of Financial Aid and Scholarships · 330-941-3505 · ysufinaid@ysu.edu. They're happy to answer questions and get to know prospective families.

Questions about this guide or Crown Roots? Jeff Pollastro · jeff.pollastro@crownroots.org · crownroots.org

Sources: YSU Office of Financial Aid and Scholarships (reviewed with their office, November 2026); YSU Scholarships for Excellence and Scholarship Opportunities pages; Ohio Admin. Code 3356-8-10. Program details change every year.